

DECEPTIVE SIMPLICITY

a retrospective on the life and work of Massimo Vignelli



“If you can design one thing, you can design everything.”

Vignelli, together with his wife and lifelong design partner **Lella**, and the generations of gifted designers who worked at his New York agency Vignelli Associates, produced many of the most iconic designs of the past 50 years, defining visual identities for the New York City subway, IBM, American Airlines and the US National Parks Service. His work extended beyond graphic design to encompass consumer products, furniture, clothing, architecture and even the interior of a church.

Those principles were developed during the golden age of 20th century modernist design, the decades following World War II when the systematic approach to graphic design pioneered during the 1920s and ‘30s by movements such as the **Bauhaus**, **Constructivism** and de Stijl was refined into a rigorous set of maxims and processes suitable for day-to day commercial work. The body of design theory and best practice formulated by the modernists continues to serve as bedrock knowledge for today’s designers.

Vignelli, along with other leading 20th century designers such as **Josef Müller-Brockmann** and **Paul Rand**, with whom much of his career overlapped, made a significant contribution to that process of professionalization. His work applied the principles he had learned from his forebears and peers with uncompromising rigor, and his teaching in turn refined and extended them further.

Though he was a man of great personal warmth and humor, **Vignelli’s** conception of the nature and practice of design was austere. For him, design was a severe, ascetic discipline, demanding self-denial and humility. The designer’s ultimate objective is not the pursuit of beauty, self-expression or wealth, but rather the forensic application of the guiding principles of design to every project, large or small.

Where: 931 Trojan Way,
Everett Wa, 98201

Time: 4pm - 7pm

Tickets: \$55



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